

Weekly Reading Reflections #8: Sergio Monterroso

Confederate Controversy

Beetham Reflections

Beetham says that Confederate monuments are, ironically, not set in stone and “adapt to ever-shifting circumstances in fluctuating landscapes.” (Page 91). Sometimes they move because of accidents, drowsy police work, or municipal construction projects. This reminded me of the parallel with the German asbestos-ridden museum except the removal of that building led to the Humboldt Forum. I guess the same can be assumed for removal of monuments: if you remove a Confederate memorial, what do you put in its place? Does removal offer a venue for an even worse icon as a community compromise.

The location of the statues is also important to Beetham, who notes that they’re typically near seats of government or local courts of justice to terrorize and mark the land and government as belonging to White supremacists. Last week, we looked at the Dahlenega square and found a marker that discussed how the square used to be a center of free speech, community commerce, and other great aspects of “the golden days” of Dahlenega. In my personal research on Colonel Price when he was my first topic for this class project, I read about frequent Confederate events held in the town square. Although we don’t have a statue of Robert E. Lee riding a horse in the town square, the frequent events held there to mark Dahlenega’s center of life, government, and justice as belonging to Whites worked the same.

Thompson Reflections

Thompson continued the argument that Beetham made that monuments “aren’t history lessons—they’re pledges of allegiance. As the story of *Freedom* reminds us, monuments are created and controlled by powerful people to advance their own interests. Monuments present a specific version of history, without room for doubts or questions.” We’ve talked frequently about a hypothetical of whether nationalism requires an element of history in it: our answer has always returned to the “what is nationalism?” question. Here, the statues serve as a White history allegiance to a White nationalism definition. But now the question is on the other foot, what is history? Stone Mountain is barely old enough to be “Georgia history” but that doesn’t matter because it fits the allegiance requirement. Politics can literally void a past. Stone Mountain was just a sleazy project for money with little authenticity, but now it is treated as history.

Iconography on College Campuses

College campuses are often the center of many of these discussions on Confederate iconography because we’re (hopefully) more educated than the anti-vaxxer Grandma in the countryside yelling about “heritage not hate.” Still, we must examine the arguments made in the discourse. In this case, we’ve seen the word “heritage” before in the semester, and we can apply that definition to this argument. Southern heritage, understood as Nora would put the word, is being used for the future by pulling from the past. These monuments are the *lieux de memiore* that embody that heritage used for contemporary politics. They have political lives associated to them that are irrelevant to the actual history

behind the monument: Stone Mountain was used by the Georgia Governor as a stand against school racial integration. Often when we're litigating the issue of these monuments, the conversation goes surface deep of "heritage (of hate) vs. acceptance" when the actual conversation is about the political and social life of these monuments. One side of the aisle hates these monuments and because of that, the other side will defend and use them as a symbol of their authority. Monuments are built to be taken down according to their social and political life. They're in public places to be provocative of these messages and their life until the side that is fueling their life eventually loses authority.